by Parliament by sending it back for review but is bound to sign it if Parliament returns it to them. But there is no time limit on when a President can sign a bill. Zail Singh, for instance, delayed signing a 1986 postal bill passed by Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in Parliament because he found it draconian. In doing so, Singh rendered it infructuous.

Those who believe Murmu will be a docile, rubber-stamp president need only check her track record as Jharkhand governor when Raghubar Das was the BJP chief minister. Murmu had in June 2017 returned a Bill seeking to amend two tenancy acts—the Chhotanagpur Tenancy (CNT) Act and the Santhal Pargana Tenancy (SPT) Act—for giving rights to tribals to make commercial use of their lands and for allowing the government to use the land for public projects. Murmu refused to give her consent, forcing the Das government to withdraw the bill later. Murmu believed the proposed amendments would make the tribals vulnerable as allowing commercial use of their land would put them at the mercy of vested interests and pluck them from their roots.

BJP'S TRIBAL GAMEPLAN

There was more than symbolism in Modi's choice of gifting the nation a tribal president to celebrate the 'Azadi ka Amrit Mahotsav' marking India's 75th year of Independence. It also had a large element of cold political calculation. The BJP, whenever it has been in power at the Centre, has always used the selection of the president to convey a strong political message and boost its electoral chances. When Vajpayee was the prime minister of a coalition government, he chose eminent scientist Kalam as president partly because he was a Muslim, and it would sit well with the party's allies and the Opposition. When Modi became prime minister, he nominated Kovind because of his Dalit origins, a gesture that would help the party win favour with the powerful political constituency of scheduled castes. They had taken a leaf from the Congress playbook, when the party appointed former diplomat K.R. Narayanan as the country's first Dalit president and later Pratibha Patil, who became the country's first woman to hold the high office. Indira Gandhi chose Zail Singh, a Sikh, and two Muslims—Zakir Hussain and Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed—as presidents during her prime ministerships.

Some see Murmu's elevation as an effort by Modi and the BJP to subsume the indigenous religious identity of the tribals under the wider Hindutva umbrella. The right-wing, however, is projecting it as an endeavour to build an inclusive India, to counter the charges of divisive politics against it. It's a beginning, they say, towards dissolving caste-class barriers, and ending the margin-mainstream, tribal-non-tribal binaries. Placing a woman, that too from a tribal background from Mayurbhanj district, which has a human development index (HDI) of 0.15 per cent, the second lowest in the country, on the top perch of the country is a political masterstroke. Several opposition parties, including the BJD in Odisha and the JMM in Jharkhand, backed her presidency against the Opposition's choice of Yashwant Sinha, enabling her to win by a handsome majority.

All of which segues well with the BJP's larger and longer term gameplan to woo tribals and women. While the RSS has a long history of working with tribals through its Vanvasi Kalyan Ashrams, even if it was to counter the influence of Christian missionaries, the Congress has always fared better electorally in the seats reserved for STs. Only recently have the combined efforts of the BJP-RSS paid off. Nalin Mehta, author of *The New BJP*, points out that in 2014, the BJP won 26 of the 47 ST reserved seats. In 2019, however, the party upped its tally to 31, with the Congress winning only four. Even in 55 other Lok Sabha constituencies where the tribal vote was dominant, the BJP won a majority with 36 seats and 46 per cent vote share in 2019. Strangely though, as Mehta observes, the BJP has been unable to replicate this success in central India where it lost the tribal-dominated states of Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh in 2018 to the Congress and Jharkhand to the JMM coalition in 2019.

POLITICAL SYMBOLISM CAN TAKE THE BJP ONLY SO FAR. TRIBALS NEED A REAL CHANGE IN THEIR SOCIO-ECONOMIC CONDITIONS

The BJP, however, remains relentless and innovative in its pursuit of winning over the tribals. Union home minister Amit Shah recently pointed out that the Tribal Sub-Plan budgets have increased four-fold, from Rs 21,000 crore in 2013-14, before Modi came to power, to Rs 86,000 crore in 2021-22. The special initiatives launched include piped water for 12.8 million tribal homes and 3.8 million pucca houses for them. The budget for Eklavya Model Schools, specially developed for tribals, has grown six-fold to Rs 1,418 crore. The Modi government has also set up district mineral foundations to enable 30 per cent earnings from mining activities to be spent on tribal welfare. Simultaneously, it is paying homage to tribal heroes, declaring the birth anniversary of tribal freedom-fighter Birsa Munda on November 15 as Janjatiya Gaurav Diwas. An additional Rs 200 crore is being spent to develop museums for other tribal freedom-fighters. Experts, though, warn that the current BJP and successive governments should know that cultural solidarity and political symbolism can get them only so far. Only real change in their socio-economic condition, which is currently wretched, will help tribals feel a part of India. That said, any development should not be at the cost of subsuming their unique identity and culture. It's a fine line India must tread. President Murmu has shown the way. ■